

UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

FRIDAY, 18 SEPTEMBER 2026

0 must-know stories, 5 Prelims facts, 10 editorials and 0 explainers, picked from 35 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

QUICK READ

PM Modi to inaugurate International Conference on Future of Environment and Climate Dynamics on September 19

[DD News: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

QUICK READ

As tigers spill beyond reserves, India rethinks conservation

Forty-five-year-old Mahadeva Gowda was tending to his cotton farm in the village of Badagalapura in the southern Indian state of Karnataka when a tiger lunged at him from behind. He was caught unaware: He says he wasn't aware that the forest department was trying to capture a tiger roaming through the areas.

[Mongabay India: source](#)

ECONOMY

QUICK READ

MDR apprehension unlikely to spur higher cash usage: RBI Deputy Governor

From October 15, a 0.4% MDR will apply to person-to-merchant UPI payments above Rs. 2,000. The charge will be paid by merchants, not consumers, and will be capped at Rs. 300 for transactions of Rs. 75,000 or more

[The Hindu: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

QUICK READ

As Project Cheetah completes 4 years, big cat population in India rises to 52

The next phase of the cheetah restoration programme involves expanding suitable habitat for cheetahs and establishing a comprehensive, long term cheetah meta population in India.

[The Hindu: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

QUICK READ

NMDC targets Net Zero operational emissions by 2047

The Net Zero roadmap has been divided into three phases – the short-term will cover FY 2026 to FY 2030, medium-term FY2030 to FY2040 and the long-term will run from FY 2040 to FY 2047...

[The Hindu: source](#)

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS2 Does the BRICS summit signify a shift for Indian foreign policy?

Open the piece for its argument.

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 Successful BRICS Summit

Open the piece for its argument.

[EPW](#)

GS2 GS3 AI capitalist China vs command-control US

China and the United States pursue contrasting approaches to artificial intelligence development. The US government leads with public resources and control, while China allows companies to innovate freely. China focuses on commercialising AI, making it widely accessible for industrial applications. The US faces deployment challenges as it imports many manufactured goods. Global AI commerce rules will likely reflect Chinese commercial values and priorities.

[Economic Times](#)

GS2 A war room for India in an age of sanctions

A coordinated response is essential as sanctions increasingly target entire transactions

[The Hindu](#)

GS1 Dire Straits for the Hegemon

Open the piece for its argument.

[EPW](#)

GS3 New fault lines: On Manipur's Kuki-Zo-Naga conflict

Manipur's new Kuki-Zo-Naga conflict needs firm, even-handed State action

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 Prepare for Rising Inflation

Open the piece for its argument.

[EPW](#)

GS3 Complex priorities: On UPI transactions, MDR charges

A fear of political fallout has led to an overly complex MDR structure on UPI

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 Jarasandha principle and party demerger

Indian politics sees party splits, with Trinamool Congress now facing a logo dispute. This mirrors corporate demergers, where brand identity becomes crucial. The Election Commission's action freezes the party's name and symbol temporarily. Both factions claim the original party's legacy and voter loyalty. Such separations create fights over authenticity and historical claims.

[Economic Times](#)

GS3 AI makes editors read the writer as well as the text

Editors are often caught between their duty to the readers and employers and the demands of the publishing process

[The Hindu](#)

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- RBI may deliver two rate hikes by CY 2026:Analysts (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- Moody's raises India fiscal 2027 GDP growth forecast to 7% on West Asia resilience (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- A BRICS balance sheet (International Relations) [Frontline](#)
- Bank of Japan hikes rates to 31-year high to battle inflation (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- EAC-PM member Sanjeev Sanyal suggests ending population control policies amid falling fertility (Society) [Economic Times](#)
- Four India-based companies bear the brunt of U.S.' Iran sanctions (International Relations) [The Hindu](#)
- Net direct tax collection rises 13% to over Rs. 12.12 lakh crore till September 17 (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- Data show India yielded to U.S. curbs on oil imports (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- CBDT removes arrest-related provisions under Rule 225; valuers face tighter disclosure norms as registration deadline extended (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- Private financing critical for Viksit Bharat goal: Economic Affairs Secretary (Governance & Policy) [Economic Times](#)
- Biotechnology and healthcare: where we are in India, and where we need to go (Science & Technology) [The Hindu](#)
- How rankings such as NIRF do more harm than good (Education) [The Hindu](#)

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 0 must-know, 5 Prelims facts, 12 in the news, 10 editorials, 0 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — Environment & Ecology (4), Economy (1). **Nothing today in** — Polity & Constitution, Governance & Policy, International Relations, Social Justice & Welfare, Health, Education, Agriculture & Allied, Infrastructure & Energy, Science & Technology, Internal Security, Defence, Disaster Management, History, Art & Culture, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): nothing today · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 2 · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 1 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: nothing today

Full text — 0 of 15 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 8, EPW 3, Economic Times 2, DD News 1, Mongabay India 1

Built 04 Oct 2026, 00:10 IST by UPSC Intel. Notes quote the reports; check the source before quoting a figure in an answer.